

LCDs. The ZEXX webcam from Zen has its complete body built of metal, with a screw mechanism to adjust the swivel—if the screw loosens too much, the camera tends to pop out of the base.

The Logitech QuickCam Easy is the black-coloured clone of the QuickCam Go, and has a flexible base. The Logitech trio—the QuickCam Family, Chat, and Messenger are identical but employ a different colour scheme. Logitech's good build quality remains on par for its complete range in this category. The Zebronics 1300 WC looks distinct, sporting two lenses on the front, but it has a somewhat cheap plastic feel to it.

Performance

In Daylight

Compared to the Logitech QuickCam Easy and QuickCam Messenger, the Logitech QuickCam Family and QuickCam Chat performed poorly. The Microsoft VX-1000 was average in terms of sharpness and contrast, but in terms of brightness, it was slightly below par. The ZENX was average; the Zebronics 1300WC outperforming it

by a huge margin. The Zebronics 350 WC performed much poorer than the 1300 WC. The Genius Look 312P failed to impress—below-par performance.

In Fluorescent Light

The QuickCam Easy and the QuickCam Messenger webcams were the better performers. The Microsoft LifeCam VX-1000 and the Zebronics 1300 WC lagged in our colour reproduction test compared to the Logitech QuickCam Messenger and Easy.

Night Vision

The Zebronics 1300 WC produced the best images in the dark in this category.



Zebronics 1300 WC
Two lenses, twice the fun

Software For Your Webcam

Booru WebCam (www.booru.net)

This simple program allows capturing of images from a webcam and saving them to GIF, JPEG, BMP, TIFF, or PNG. The option to upload to an FTP server is also available. Support for text as well as image overlays with transparency is available.

Yawcam (www.yawcam.com)

Yawcam, a Java-based freeware, has some useful features over standard webcam software. Yawcam has support for motion detection, with video streaming built in. It allows for FTP upload of captured images / videos and also has an inbuilt secure Web server with password protection—this requires the motion detection feature. If you want to schedule SMS or e-mail alerts from the motion detection engine, you can use GrabMotion (www.grabmotion.com).

VirtualCamera (www.soundmorning.com)

A webcam tool that allows you to stream virtual video feeds from your computer. Even without a webcam, you can use it to send video or feed images, recorded videos, and other items through IM to friends. This program is a solution for anyone wanting to share pictures and video over the Internet. The video formats supported by the player are WMV, AVI, ASF, MPEG, RM, RMVB, and more, and image formats including JPEG, GIF, and BMP. The menu provides an easy switch for the input source (virtual / real camera).

Barcodepedia (<http://en.barcodepedia.com>)

A community-based online barcode database. Barcodepedia can be used as a barcode scanner using your webcam—just hold the barcode in front of the cam such that you can see the entire barcode in focus in the preview area of the Web page, and Barcodepedia will recognise the barcode and search the article in several databases. It then gives you all the details about the product.

Splitcamera (www.splitcamera.com)

A virtual video cloner (for webcams and camcorders) and split video capture driver (for TV-Tuners) that supports up to 64 clients (applications running on one personal computer) from a single video source. Extremely useful if you want to use a mix of multiple IM clients and videoconferencing tools at the same time. Splitcamera supports multiple video resolutions; each client can have its own resolution and disable unused resolutions to lower processor load.

Cameroid (www.cameroid.com) Phozi (www.phozi.com)

These are two cool Web sites every webcam owner should visit. It's like Mac PhotoBooth loaded into your browser. Both sites use Flash code to detect the webcam on the local client system and load images from your webcam. Cameroid allows applying different effects like colour, morph, and scene on uploaded images. Phozi supports a wide range of frames and stamps (stick-on images) and colour pencil tools too. Images created from these sites can be used as avatars on IMs and also on social networking sites.

VideoMage Producer (<http://www.hollix.com/downloads.html>)

This one allows superimposing and manipulating (fade, resize, and move) graphic images over real-time images and video received from sources like webcams, TV-Tuners, or pre-recorded files. The telestrator effect allows one to highlight special areas of a video image by drawing shapes over it. The output is stored as compressed files in the AVI and WMV formats.

Webcam Diagnostics (<http://noeld.com/programs.asp?cat=video>)

Webcam Diagnostics, as the names suggest, provides webcam-related information. Driver installation and USB issues become easy to diagnose; red circles mark serious issues, and yellow triangles point to minor issues. Right-clicking on the red / yellow marks provides a context menu to fix the problem or a potential way to fix it. In the case of corrupt USB drivers, Webcam Diagnostics points out the problem and suggests reinstallation of the drivers.